ProGlove: Who Should Run the Company Next?

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MODULE 01 · TEAM & FOUNDATIONS · CASE, READ BEFORE CLASS

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In the autumn of 2018 Thomas Kirchner was co-founder and chief executive of ProGlove, a Munich start-up that made a work glove with a barcode scanner on the back of the hand. BMW's board member Peter Schwarzenbauer had said in April that the glove supported BMW's employees at almost all of its European production and distribution sites and that BMW had just begun to introduce it in its plant in South Carolina. Munich Startup named Ikea, Lufthansa and Rewe as customers too.[1] In April ProGlove had closed a second financing round of EUR 5.5 million.[1] Its press page spoke of a team of 70.[2] In September it launched a new glove, and the announcement quoted Kirchner as chief executive and co-founder.[3]

By then Andreas König was working with Kirchner and his co-founders.[4] König had run the remote-support software company TeamViewer from May 2015. Before that he had headed Swisscom IT Services at the Swiss telecommunications company Swisscom, where he merged two business units with 4,500 employees.[5] [6] Kirchner recalled in 2022 that the founders had asked their investors for advice and that the investors gave them an advisor who was to help them on the sales side. "That was Andreas," he said.[7] In a panel published in 2025 Kirchner described the arrangement differently, as König joining the founders as chairman of the board.[8]

The founders had to decide who should run ProGlove from here. They could keep the chief executive's role among themselves, with König's advice, or hand it to an experienced manager from outside.

A Scanner on the Back of the Hand

In a video published in May 2017 Kirchner described the routine on BMW's assembly line, where workers documented a great many things before fitting them into the car. A worker took a small handheld scanner, scanned the part, got the feedback that it was the right part, put the scanner back and only then fitted the part. ProGlove had built the scanner and the feedback into the glove, so that the worker scanned, got the feedback and fitted the part at once. Kirchner put the saving at about half of the documentation time, about four seconds per scan, with about 1,000 scans per car and about 1,000 cars a day in a plant.[9] Munich Startup had put the saving at about three seconds per scan in 2016, also with about 1,000 scans per car.[10]

Munich Startup described the first product, MARK, in 2016. It was triggered with the thumb and gave the wearer optical, acoustic and haptic feedback on whether a step had been done correctly. The system consisted of a central computer unit and a work glove with integrated electronics.[10] "We started with the car industry because that is simply where the pain was greatest," Kirchner said in 2016. "By now, though, we are also in many other industries, logistics for example."[11]

A Contest, 2014 to 2015

Kirchner grew up near Dresden in a family that worked at the steelworks. He recalled in 2022 that he had not known, until he came to the Technical University of Munich (TUM) to study mechanical engineering, that one could found a company.[12] With Paul Günther and a fellow student he ran an online shop for green electronics, and he and Günther then tested a flat-rate mobility concept, through which they met Jonas Girardet. The three were working on cheap Bluetooth sensors when Günther proposed entering a contest.[12]

In 2014 the chip maker Intel ran "Make it Wearable", a competition for wearable computing ideas. Munich Startup, the Abendzeitung and Kirchner all put its prize money at half a million dollars.[13] Günther, a business administration student, gave guided tours of the BMW plant. Munich Startup wrote in 2016 that he had seen there how much a seemingly small improvement on the assembly line was worth and that most workers wore gloves anyway, and that the team soon settled on a glove.[14] [15] The team, which also included Alexander Grots, won third place.[15] [16] According to UnternehmerTUM, the innovation centre at TUM, the founders were scholarship holders of its entrepreneurship programme Manage&More. In 2015 ProGlove joined the first batch of UnternehmerTUM's TechFounders accelerator. UnternehmerTUM also records that the team built its first prototypes in its MakerSpace in Garching and developed first business relationships with Festo and BMW.[17] In 2018 the company described itself as founded by former automotive and IDEO employees.[18] Kirchner said in 2017 that the team came partly from BMW and partly from IDEO, which he called the world's biggest innovation consultancy.[19]

Kirchner recalled in 2020 that at some point the founders had faced the question of how serious they were about ProGlove, because all of them were involved in other projects or employed elsewhere at the time. At some point, he said, they simply decided.[20] ProGlove's legal entity was set up as Workaround UG with articles of association dated 4 December 2014. It was entered in the commercial register in Munich on 4 February 2015 with a share capital of EUR 500 and became Workaround GmbH, with a share capital of EUR 25,000, on 11 November 2015.[21] [22]

When the founders set their roles after the contest, Kirchner recalled in 2022, there were five of them. One, whom he called Alex, was about 15 years older than the others, who were around 27. "We thought Alex would be the right CEO, but he did not feel like it. He knew us well and said, 'Thomas, you are the CEO.'"[23] [24] The role was new to him, Kirchner recalled. "But I engaged with it and realised that it suits me. By now I like being the one who leads the way for others." He led by what the team called "Management by Walking Around", going from employee to employee every day. Asked whether he had missed building and developing things, he answered, "No, I could help others build."[23] From 11 November 2015 he was the only managing director in the commercial register.[21]

Hardware Money, 2016 to 2017

In May 2016 ProGlove closed its first financing round, USD 2.2 million led by Intel Capital, the venture arm of Intel, with the US investor GETTYLAB and Bayern Kapital, the venture capital company of the Bavarian state.[25] [26] [10] Munich Startup reported that the money was to speed up production and prepare the glove's market entry in the second half of 2016.[26] The founders told Munich Startup in 2016 that German financiers were comfortable with software and shied away from riskier hardware. Hardware needed more money because its development cycles were longer, and industrial customers

needed more persuading and usually paid later.[27] In a video published in May 2017 Kirchner said that German investors had not been willing to take enough risk and that ProGlove had two American investors.[28]

MARK was launched in October 2016.[29] Munich Startup reported that customers such as BMW and Skoda had used and tested a pre-series under real conditions and that the makers had tested more than 70 prototypes in the first months.[10] "Since we have VC money in the company, it is now of course primarily about scaling," the founders said at the launch. "We have to make revenue and want to serve as many customers as possible." Munich Startup reported that the next financing round was planned for mid-2017 and that its valuation would depend on revenue.[27]

In the same 2017 video Kirchner said that ProGlove was concentrating on the car industry in Europe, naming BMW, Audi, Volkswagen, Skoda and Porsche, that it was talking to investors about the next round and that it wanted to become the world's number one in industrial wearables.[28] In September 2017 he told an audience that ProGlove sold to about 150 customers, mostly large carmakers, had about 60 people, was raising its second round and was taking the step into the United States (Exhibit 3).[30] Looking back on the years after the contest, Kirchner said in 2022 that ProGlove had never had a marketing problem. "The customers always came to us," he said, and the founders could show investors that many customers wanted the product.[31]

Bigger in Every Direction, 2018

In October 2017 ProGlove was among seven Munich start-ups selected for German Accelerator Tech, a programme that prepared selected start-ups for entering the US market, and it went to New York. Jonas Girardet said in January 2018 that he had travelled to the United States three times in the last quarter, that ProGlove's customers included almost all European carmakers and suppliers, and that pilot tests were running in the United States and Canada. "One of our goals is to show that we can scale internationally and hold our own in the US market," he said. Within a year ProGlove wanted an independent office in the United States, integrated with the German team.[32] UnternehmerTUM later dated ProGlove's entry into the US and Canadian markets to January 2018 (Exhibit 1).[17]

On 23 April 2018 ProGlove announced its second financing round, EUR 5.5 million (USD 6.7 million) from Intel Capital, GETTYLAB, Bayern Kapital and DIVC, a German investor new to the company. Munich Startup reported that outside investors had put EUR 7.7 million into the company in total. "We are very happy with our investors," Kirchner said. "With the new financing we will concentrate on extending our product portfolio with new hardware and software." Munich Startup reported that ProGlove wanted to push its international expansion and was preparing its step into the American market with the German Accelerator. Georg Ried, managing director of Bayern Kapital, said that human workers would keep their central role in industrial processes and that this was where ProGlove's technology offered "considerable growth potential".[1] [29]

In July 2018 ProGlove's law firm announced the round. The company's own text at its end reported that since MARK's launch in October 2016 ProGlove had quadrupled its seven-figure revenue of 2016 in 2017. It named no currency and no exact figure (Exhibit 3).[29] The firm's announcement said that ProGlove would use the money to scale its glove worldwide and to connect the worker with Industry 4.0 "with ever better software".[29] Girardet had put the same goal in January 2018 as connecting the worker with the industrial Internet of Things.[32] Customers named that year by the company and the press included BMW, Ikea, Lufthansa, Rewe, Mahle, Skoda, the retailer Penny, Lufthansa Technik

Logistik Services, John Deere in the United States, Bosch in Germany and Faurecia in the United Kingdom.[1] [32] [18] [3] In September ProGlove launched the Index Trigger, a glove that, Kirchner said, customers had long been asking for.[3]

The company was hiring. In April and May 2018 its careers pages listed 51 openings, 33 of them under the heading “Full Time” and 18 under “Internship” (Exhibit 4). Among them were a Head of Sales North America and an assistant to the chief operating officer (COO) to “Create ‘ProGlove US’ from the ground up with one of our founders”. An intern was to work as executive assistant to the chief sales officer (CSO), on ProGlove’s expansion into further industries and regions and on designing and building the organisational structure of the sales team. The development page sought Android, full-stack, embedded and mobile developers, an ERP interface architect and a product owner.[33] [34] [35] The pages referred to a CSO, a COO and a chief technology officer (CTO) without naming them.[33] [34] On 23 August 2018 Girardet and Manuel Bönisch were registered as managing directors beside Kirchner.[21]

ProGlove’s financial year ended on 30 November. Its annual accounts for 2016 were published in March 2018 as a balance sheet only, and its revenue, losses and cash were not publicly disclosed (Exhibit 3).[21]

The People at the Top

The company’s text of July 2018 named four founders and their roles, Thomas Kirchner as chief executive, Jonas Girardet as COO, Paul Günther as product engineer and Alexander Grots as consultant (Exhibit 2).[29] An interviewer described Kirchner’s job in 2022 as looking after the brand, the pitches and the people while his colleagues turned mainly to sales and product development. Kirchner answered that he could still give, in his sleep, the five-minute pitch he had given investors again and again.[23]

Günther recalled in 2022 that he had been too weak in mathematics at school to study mechanical engineering. “I had no experience with electronics, nor as a programmer,” he said. He told the Abendzeitung that all four founders had always been tinkerers, and the paper added that Grots and Girardet knew product design and that Kirchner had studied mechanical engineering. “Everyone contributed something,” Günther said.[15] Girardet had written his master’s thesis on mobility patterns.[12]

Manuel Bönisch, registered as a managing director in August 2018, said in the panel published in 2025 that he had built up ProGlove’s sales, adding that it had been what the founders then thought sales was. Kirchner said in the same panel that Bönisch, like Girardet, was very structured and had built up sales, that Girardet had organised everything, that Günther was the tinkerer who stood in the workshop, and that he himself was the one on stage explaining the company. On paper, Kirchner said, the founders had studied much the same, but their skills were very different.[36] When Bönisch joined ProGlove is not documented, and the sources count the founders differently.[37]

From 10 to 100

Kirchner recalled in 2022 that the founders had brought ProGlove to EUR 10 million in revenue by trying things out. “But we had no clue how to get it from 10 to 100 million euros in revenue.”[38] He did not say in which year the company reached that figure (Exhibit 3). He described the founders sitting

together and knowing that they now had to grow. "And suddenly everyone in the room says, 'No idea! Never done it.' Phases in which we had or found answers to everything gave way more and more often to phases in which we did not know how to go on."[38]

In the panel published in 2025 Kirchner put the company at about 100 people and about 10 million in revenue, without a currency, after four years with him as chief executive. Until then, he said, the founders had agreed on strategy and argued only about whether the office should have fruit or chocolate. At that threshold they no longer quite knew the next sensible step.[39] Bönisch said that ProGlove's two hardest problems had been funding and bringing in the software for its large vision of collecting data from every worker's hand, which the founders had not been good at.[40]

How König came to the founders is told in two ways. Kirchner's 2022 account is the one in the opening, an advisor for the sales side whom the investors provided after the founders asked them for advice, and who soon got so involved that he sent emails on Sundays.[7] In the panel published in 2025 Kirchner said that the team had decided ProGlove had to move from a product-led to a sales-led organisation and that it could not do that itself. The founders went to their investors, said that they did not believe they were the perfect management and that they needed a new chief executive. The investors, he said, told them they were doing very well and gave them König as chairman of the board.[8]

König recalled in 2020 that an investor in ProGlove whom he knew well from Swisscom had asked him to talk to the founders and see whether he could help. After the first meeting he was not convinced, he said, because it felt too much like hardware to him, coming from TeamViewer. The investor persuaded him to come a second time, he got to know the people better and agreed to an advisory role. That role became so intense, he said, that he called one of the founders on Saturdays and Sundays.[41] The investor was not named.

König, an Austrian, had spent 16 years at the data storage company NetApp, last as senior vice president and general manager for Europe, the Middle East and Africa. He moved to Swisscom in 2012 and, as head of Swisscom IT Services, merged two business units with 4,500 employees. On 4 May 2015, aged 49, he became chief executive of TeamViewer.[5] [6] Oliver Steil had led TeamViewer since January 2018.[42] König later recalled about three years at TeamViewer.[41] The terms on which he advised ProGlove were not publicly disclosed.

Two Ways Forward

The founders keep the chief executive's role, with König advising. This is the arrangement Kirchner described in 2022, an advisor for the sales side whom the investors provided,[7] and, by his account in the panel published in 2025, what the investors offered when the founders asked for a new chief executive, telling them they were doing very well and giving them König as chairman.[8] Kirchner recalled in 2022 that the role had been new to him when the founders set their roles and that he found it suited him.[23]

Hand the chief executive's role to an experienced outsider. By Kirchner's account in the panel published in 2025, this is what the founders asked their investors for, after the team concluded that ProGlove had to become a sales-led organisation and could not build one itself.[8]

König, who was advising the founders, recalled in 2020 that ProGlove had at first felt too much like hardware to him, until a second meeting changed his mind.[41] No source shows what an outside chief executive would cost in salary, shares or control, what Girardet, Günther and Grots thought, or whether anyone else was considered for the role.

Autumn 2018

In the autumn of 2018 ProGlove's glove was in use at almost all of BMW's European production and distribution sites, by BMW's account. The company had raised EUR 7.7 million from outside investors by Munich Startup's count, and that spring it had advertised 51 openings, among them jobs in sales, software and its US business. Kirchner was chief executive, Girardet and Bönisch had been registered as managing directors beside him in August, and König was advising the founders. Who should run ProGlove from here, and what should each of the founders do?

Exhibit 1: ProGlove, 2014 to October 2018

Date	Event	Reported by
2014	Third place in Intel's "Make it Wearable" contest, prize money given as USD 100,000 to 250,000	Munich Startup, Kirchner, Abendzeitung
4 February 2015	Entered in the commercial register in Munich, share capital EUR 500, articles dated 4 December 2014	Commercial register
2015	First batch of the TechFounders accelerator, first business relationships with Festo and BMW	UnternehmerTUM
11 November 2015	Name Workaround GmbH, share capital EUR 25,000, Kirchner the only managing director	Commercial register
May 2016	First financing round, USD 2.2 million (EUR 2 million in one report), Intel Capital, GETTYLAB, Bayern Kapital	Law firm, Munich Startup
October 2016	MARK launched in Europe, after pre-series tests with customers such as BMW and Skoda	Munich Startup, company
May 2017	Focus on carmakers in Europe, talks for the next round, aim to become number one in industrial wearables	Kirchner (recording)
September 2017	About 150 customers and about 60 people, second round being raised	Kirchner (recording)
October 2017	Selected for German Accelerator Tech, New York	Munich Startup
January 2018	Pilot tests in the USA and Canada. UnternehmerTUM's later account dates the market entry there to this month	Girardet, UnternehmerTUM
April 2018	Second financing round, EUR 5.5 million (USD 6.7 million), with DIVC as a new investor. EUR 7.7 million from outside investors in total. US step still being prepared	Munich Startup, law firm
April and May 2018	51 openings on the careers pages (Exhibit 4)	Company
July 2018	Revenue of 2016, seven figures, quadrupled in 2017	Company text in the law firm's release
23 August 2018	Girardet and Bönisch registered as managing directors beside Kirchner	Commercial register
14 September 2018	Index Trigger glove launched, Kirchner quoted as chief executive and co-founder	The Manufacturer

The company gave 2014 as its founding year, the Abendzeitung 2015. "Recording" marks figures from recorded talks, reported in paraphrase.

Source: compiled by the case writer from the sources in notes [16], [21], [17], [25], [26], [10], [29], [28], [30], [32], [18], [1] and [3].

Exhibit 2: The People at the Top of ProGlove, Autumn 2018

Person	Role in 2018	Training and earlier work	What the sources say each did
Thomas Kirchner	Co-founder, chief executive. Only registered managing director from November 2015 to August 2018	Mechanical engineering at TUM. Online shop and mobility concept with Günther before ProGlove	Named chief executive by the older co-founder Alex (2022). Found the role suited him (2022). Gave the five-minute investor pitch many times (2022). The one on stage explaining the company (2025)
Jonas Girardet	Co-founder, COO. Managing director from August 2018	Product design (2022). Master's thesis on mobility patterns (2022)	Spoke for ProGlove's US plans and made three US trips in late 2017 (2018). Very structured, organised everything (Kirchner, 2025)
Paul Günther	Co-founder, product engineer	Business administration. Guided tours of the BMW plant as a student. No experience in electronics or programming, in his words (2022)	Had the idea for the glove, by the Abendzeitung's account (2022). The tinkerer in the workshop (Kirchner, 2025)
Alexander Grots	Co-founder, consultant	Product design (2022). About 15 years older than the others, if he is the "Alex" of Kirchner's account (2022)	If he is Alex, seen as the right chief executive when roles were set, and declined (2022)
Manuel Bönisch	Managing director from 23 August 2018. Whether he counts as a founder is told differently	Not documented	Built up sales, by his own account (2025). Very structured, built up sales (Kirchner, 2025). When he joined is not documented
Andreas König, advisor	Advisor on the sales side (Kirchner, 2022) or chairman of the board (Kirchner, 2025)	16 years at NetApp, last head of Europe, Middle East and Africa. At Swisscom from 2012, as head of Swisscom IT Services merged two units with 4,500 employees	Chief executive of TeamViewer from 4 May 2015. TeamViewer led by Oliver Steil since January 2018. About three years at TeamViewer, as he recalled (2020)

Years in brackets give the year of the telling. (2025) marks the panel published in 2025, whose event date is not verified. The founders' roles come from the company's text in its law firm's release of July 2018. When König began to work with the founders is not documented. The job ads of May 2018 referred to a CSO, a COO, a CTO and a head of people and culture without naming the first three. Kirchner's 2022 account names the older co-founder only as "Alex". The case writer identifies him as Alexander Grots, the only founder of that first name in the company's lists. Statements marked 2025 come from the recorded panel and are reported in paraphrase. The panel's moderator called the founders industrial engineers, which the 2022 Abendzeitung account does not support for Günther, Girardet and Grots.

Source: compiled by the case writer from the sources in notes [29], [21], [12], [23], [15], [32], [36], [33], [34], [5], [6], [42] and [41].

Exhibit 3: ProGlove in Figures, 2016 to 2018

Measure	Figure	Date	Basis
First financing round	USD 2.2 million (EUR 2 million in one report)	May 2016	Law firm, Munich Startup
Second financing round	EUR 5.5 million (USD 6.7 million)	April 2018	Law firm, Munich Startup
Capital from outside investors, total	EUR 7.7 million	April 2018	Munich Startup
Revenue 2016	Seven figures, currency not stated	2016	Company text, July 2018
Revenue 2017	Four times the revenue of 2016	2017	Company text, July 2018
Revenue, as recalled	EUR 10 million, year not stated	Recalled in 2022	Kirchner, interview
Revenue, as recalled	About 10 million, currency not stated, after four years	Panel published in 2025	Kirchner, panel (recording)
People	About 60	September 2017	Kirchner, talk (recording)
People	“A team of 70 creative minds”	January and May 2018	Company press page
People, as recalled	About 100, after four years	Panel published in 2025	Kirchner, panel (recording)
Customers	About 150, mostly large carmakers	September 2017	Kirchner, talk (recording)
Markets	Europe from October 2016. Pilot tests in the USA and Canada by January 2018, the US step still being prepared in April 2018	2016 to 2018	Girardet, Munich Startup, UnternehmerTUM
Annual accounts	Financial year to 30 November. Accounts for 2016 published as a balance sheet only	March 2018	Commercial register listing

“Recording” marks figures from recorded talks, reported in paraphrase from automatic captions. The press page carried the same staff figure in January and in May 2018.

Source: compiled by the case writer from the sources in notes [25], [26], [1], [29], [38], [39], [30], [18], [32], [17] and [21].

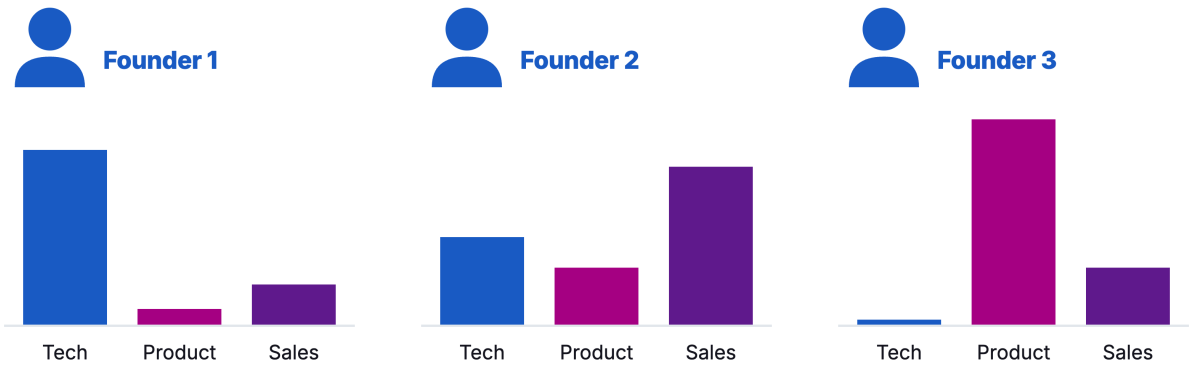
Exhibit 4: Openings on ProGlove's Careers Pages, April and May 2018

Page and team	Full time	Internship
Business, captured 21 May 2018	**16**	**11**
Marketing	2	2
Direct sales	4	2
Indirect sales	2	1
After sales	1	2
Sales operations	4	2
People and culture	1	1
Finance	2	1
Development, captured 18 May 2018	**11**	**5**
Supply chain and production, captured 15 April 2018	**6**	**2**
All three pages	**33**	**18**

Selected listing	Team	Listed under
Head of Sales North America	Direct sales	Full time
Executive Assistant to CSO, working with the CSO on expansion into further industries and regions and on the sales team's organisational structure	Direct sales	Internship
Assistant to COO, to "Create 'ProGlove US' from the ground up with one of our founders"	Sales operations	Full time
Senior Finance Management	Finance	Full time
Assistant to CTO	Development	Internship
Android, full-stack, embedded and mobile developers, an ERP interface architect and a product owner	Development	Full time

Counted by the case writer, one listing per job description offered for download, classed by the pages' own headings "Full Time" and "Internship". One business internship appears under both people and culture and finance. Three listings under "Full Time" are internships or temporary jobs by their own title. Whether every listing was still open on the capture date cannot be told from the pages.

Source: compiled by the case writer from ProGlove's careers pages as captured by the Internet Archive, see notes [33], [34] and [35].



Founder skill bars, the anchor graphic of Module 01

Endnotes

1. Simon Tischer, “ProGlove erhält 5,5 Millionen Euro Investment”, Munich Startup, 23 April 2018, https://www.munich-startup.de/news/proglove-investment, accessed 2026-10-19. Quotes translated from German by the case writer.
2. ProGlove, press page, proglove.de, snapshot of 13 May 2018, Internet Archive, https://web.archive.org/web/20180513075302/http://www.proglove.de/press/, accessed 2026-10-19.
3. “Putting humans at the centre of the next industrial revolution”, The Manufacturer, 14 September 2018, https://www.themanufacturer.com/articles/putting-humans-centre-next-industrial-revolution/, accessed 2026-10-19.
4. The sources do not date the start of König’s work with the founders. The case places it before the end of October 2018 because Kirchner’s accounts of 2022 and of the panel published in 2025 put his advice or chairmanship before the founders’ decision on the chief executive’s role, which the case leaves open.
5. “Swisscom-Manager übernimmt bei Teamviewer”, Netzwoche, 5 May 2015, https://www.netzwoche.ch/News/2015/05/05/Swisscom-Manager-uebernimmt-bei-Teamviewer.aspx, accessed 2026-10-19.
6. “Un nouveau CEO pour TeamViewer”, Solutions Numériques, 12 May 2015, https://www.solutions-numeriques.com/?p=15883, accessed 2026-10-19.
7. Thomas Kirchner, interview by Peter Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022, https://www.meisterstunde.de/proglove-gruender-thomas-kirchner/, accessed 2026-10-19. Translated from German by the case writer.
8. Thomas Kirchner and Manuel Bönisch in conversation with Johannes Pohl, recorded panel, Startupland, YouTube, published 30 April 2025, 07:17 to 07:53, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uVkYPVnMnmA, accessed 2026-10-19. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions. Speakers are not labelled in the recording and are identified by the case writer from content and the moderator’s questions.
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10. Regina Bruckschlögl, “Porträt ProGlove oder: Der Handschuh, der mitdenkt”, Munich Startup, 19 October 2016, https://www.munich-startup.de/14820/proglove-or-the-glove-that-thinks-for-itself/, accessed 2026-10-19.
11. Bruckschlögl, “Porträt ProGlove”, 19 October 2016. Translated from German by the case writer.
12. Kirchner, interview by Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022.
13. Bruckschlögl, “Porträt ProGlove”, 19 October 2016, Abendzeitung München, article with Paul Günther in the series “Münchens Zukunftsmacher”, 23 August 2022, https://www.abendzeitung-muenchen.de/muenchen/muenchens-zukunftsmacher-der-traum-vom-klugen-handschuh-art-838372,PRINT, accessed 2026-10-19, and Kirchner, interview by Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022, where Kirchner recalls Günther naming the sum. Munich Startup and Kirchner say dollars, the Abendzeitung US dollars.
14. Bruckschlögl, “Porträt ProGlove”, 19 October 2016.
15. Abendzeitung München, article with Paul Günther in the series “Münchens Zukunftsmacher”, 23 August 2022, https://www.abendzeitung-muenchen.de/muenchen/muenchens-zukunftsmacher-der-traum-vom-klugen-handschuh-art-838372,PRINT, accessed 2026-10-19. Quotes translated from German by the case writer.
16. Sources differ on the prize. Munich Startup gave USD 150,000 in 2016 (Bruckschlögl, “Porträt ProGlove”, 19 October 2016). Kirchner recalled USD 100,000 in 2022 (interview by Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022). In two talks in 2017 he spoke of USD 250,000 in total (Thomas Kirchner, talk, Hello Tomorrow, YouTube, published 17 February 2017, 03:56 to 04:05, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AMHFiT4FN_w, and Thomas Kirchner, talk on rapid prototyping, Problemsolver, 13 September 2017, starwings, YouTube, 10:35 to 10:46, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xhi_d7PxLiQ, both accessed 2026-10-19 and reported from the automatic captions). The Abendzeitung wrote in 2022 that Intel later raised the USD 100,000 to USD 250,000 (Abendzeitung München, 23 August 2022).
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18. ProGlove, press page, proglove.de, snapshots of 12 January and 13 May 2018, Internet Archive, https://web.archive.org/web/20180112193725/http://www.proglove.de/press/ and https://web.archive.org/web/20180513075302/http://www.proglove.de/press/, and team page, snapshot of 21 May 2018, https://web.archive.org/web/20180521194819/http://www.proglove.de/company/team-3/, all accessed 2026-10-19.
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21. North Data, register listing for Workaround GmbH, Amtsgericht München HRB 216605, entries of 4 December 2014, 4 February 2015, 11 November 2015, 19 April 2016, 15 March 2018 and 23 August 2018, https://www.northdata.de/Workaround+GmbH,+M%C3%BCnchen/Amtsgericht+M%C3%BCnchen+HRB+216605, accessed 2026-10-19. North Data lists the publications of the commercial register. The managing director registered on 4 February 2015 is not named there.
22. The company gave December 2014 as its founding date in 2018, on its press page and in its text in GÖRG, "GÖRG advises Workaround on second financing round", 11 July 2018, https://www.goerg.de/en/news/press_releases/goerg_advises_workaround_on_second_financing_round.47586.html , accessed 2026-10-19. North Data lists the company's earlier name as Workaround UG. The Abendzeitung wrote in 2022 that the founders started their company in 2015 (Abendzeitung München, 23 August 2022).
23. Kirchner, interview by Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022. Translated from German by the case writer. The question about building and the description of his job are the interviewer's.
24. Kirchner's account names this co-founder only as "Alex". The case writer identifies him as Alexander Grots, the only founder of that first name in the company's own lists of 2018, in GÖRG's release of July 2018 (see the note on the founding date) and in "German Accelerator Tech: ProGlove startet im Big Apple", interview with Jonas Girardet, Munich Startup, 10 January 2018, https://www.munich-startup.de/en/31862/proglove-new-york/, accessed 2026-10-19. Kirchner's account also counts five people when the roles were set, while the company named four founders.
25. GÖRG, "GÖRG berät die Workaround GmbH („ProGlove") bei einer Finanzierungsrunde", 5 August 2016, https://www.goerg.de/de/aktuelles/veroeffentlichungen/05-08-2016/goerg-beraet-die-workaround-gmbh-proglove-bei-einer-finanzierungsrunde, accessed 2026-10-19.
26. Regina Bruckschlögl, "ProGlove holt sich Bayern Kapital mit ins Boot", Munich Startup, 30 May 2016, https://www.munich-startup.de/11169/proglove-holt-sich-bayern-kapital-mit-ins-boot/, accessed 2026-10-19. Munich Startup gave the round as EUR 2 million.
27. Bruckschlögl, "Porträt ProGlove", 19 October 2016. The quote is unattributed in the article, which spoke with the founders. Translated from German by the case writer.
28. Kirchner, video portrait, Gründerszene, 31 May 2017, 01:06 to 01:17 and 02:35 to 02:58. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions.
29. GÖRG, "GÖRG advises Workaround on second financing round", 11 July 2018, https://www.goerg.de/en/news/press_releases/goerg_advises_workaround_on_second_financing_round.47586.html , and "GÖRG berät Workaround bei der zweiten Finanzierungsrunde", 10 July 2018, https://www.goerg.de/de/aktuelles/veroeffentlichungen/10-07-2018/goerg-beraet-workaround-bei-der-zweiten-finanzierungsrunde, both accessed 2026-10-19. The founding, the roles, the revenue claim and the awards come from the company's text at the end of the release, the use of the money from the firm's own announcement.
30. Kirchner, talk, Problemsolver, 13 September 2017, 11:18 to 11:38. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions.
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33. ProGlove, careers page "Business", proglove.de, snapshot of 21 May 2018, Internet Archive, https://web.archive.org/web/20180521073149/http://www.proglove.de/company/careers/business/, accessed 2026-10-19. German job texts translated by the case writer.

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35. ProGlove, careers page “Supply chain and production”, proglove.de, snapshot of 15 April 2018, Internet Archive, https://web.archive.org/web/20180415050431/http://www.proglove.de/company/careers/production/, accessed 2026-10-19.
36. Kirchner and Bönisch, panel, Startupland, published 30 April 2025, 10:23 to 10:29 and 12:02 to 12:42. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions, speakers identified by the case writer.
37. The company named four founders in 2016 and 2018 (Munich Startup, 19 October 2016, GÖRG, July 2018, Munich Startup, 10 January 2018). Kirchner recalled five people when the roles were set (Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022). In the panel published in 2025 he spoke of four to six co-founders and Bönisch of an extended founding team (Startupland panel, published 30 April 2025, 03:32 to 03:38 and 05:32 to 05:35, reported from the automatic captions).
38. Kirchner, interview by Wagner, Meisterstunde, 23 March 2022. Translated from German by the case writer.
39. Kirchner and Bönisch, panel, Startupland, published 30 April 2025, 06:36 to 07:25. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions, speaker identified by the case writer.
40. Kirchner and Bönisch, panel, Startupland, published 30 April 2025, 05:47 to 06:19, in answer to a question addressed to Bönisch. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions.
41. Andreas König, interview, Product Lessons podcast, YouTube, 6 November 2020, 08:52 and 09:06 to 10:08, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=g_PeHbzptfo, accessed 2026-10-19. Reported in paraphrase from the automatic captions.
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